

The Complaints of Poverty (Excerpt)



POEM TEXT

1 When winter's rage upon the cottage falls,
2 And the wind rushes through the gaping walls,
3 When ninepence must their daily wants supply,
4 With hunger pinched and cold, the children cry;
5 The gathered sticks but little warmth afford,
6 And half-supplied the platter meets the board.
7 Returned at night, if wholesome viands fail,
8 He from the pipe extracts a smoky meal:
9 And when, to gather strength and still his woes,
10 He seeks his last redress in soft repose,
11 The tattered blanket, erst the fleas' retreat,
12 Denies his shiv'ring limbs sufficient heat;
13 Teased with the squalling babes' nocturnal cries,
14 He restless on the dusty pillow lies.
15 But when pale sickness wounds with direful blow,
16 Words but imperfectly his mis'ry show;
17 Unskilful how to treat the fierce disease,
18 Well-meaning ignorance curtails our days.
19 In a dark room and miserable bed
20 Together lie the living and the dead.
21 Oh shocking scene! Fate sweeps whole tribes away,
22 And frees the parish of th' reluctant pay!
23 Where's the physician now, whom heav'n ordains
24 Fate to arrest, and check corroding pains?
25 Or he's detained by those of high degree,
26 Or won't prescribe without a golden fee.
27 But should old age bring on its rev'rend hoar,
28 When strength decayed admits his toil no more,
29 He begs itinerant, with halting pace,
30 And, mournful, tells his melancholy case,
31 With meagre cheek and formidable beard,
32 A tattered dress of various rags prepared.
33 Base covetise, who wants the soul to give,
34 Directs the road where richer neighbours live;
35 And pride, unmindful of its parent dust,
36 Scares with the dungeon and the whipping-post.

when families have little money to pay for their daily needs and their children cry, hurting from cold and hunger—in such times, a few scavenged sticks don't go far to heat the house, and the dishes go to the table only half full. Coming home at night and finding no healthy, abundant food, the father of the family makes do with a "meal" of pipe smoke. When, hoping to strengthen himself and take a break from his misery, he turns to sleep as his last resort, he finds that his ragged blanket (which is full of fleas) doesn't offer his shivering body nearly enough warmth. Troubled by the sound of his children crying all night, he just lies there on his dusty pillow, unable to get any rest. And when disease strikes its terrible blow, words can't capture how much a poor man suffers. Since they don't know how to treat serious illnesses, well-meaning but ignorant friends end up cutting their neighbors' lives short. In a dark room, in a grim bed, the living and the dead all lie together. Oh, horrible sight! Fate does away with whole families—and liberates the church from having to give up even the meager, grudging charity they would have offered the dead. Where, in moments like this, is the doctor, whose god-given duty it is to stop such cruel deaths and to soothe pain? Either he's already busy working for people from a higher social class, or he refuses to help if people can't pay him a high fee. If a poor man manages to reach grey-headed old age, when he becomes too weak to work, he becomes a wandering, limping beggar, sadly telling his tragic story; his cheeks are thin, his beard unkempt, and his clothes just a haphazard collection of rags. Lowly, greedy people who lack the heart to help just tell him to go down the road to where their richer neighbors live—and the proud, ignoring the fact that they're mortals just like this poor beggar, threaten him with jail or floggings.



THEMES



CLASS, POVERTY, AND INJUSTICE

The outraged speaker of "The Complaints of Poverty" rails against the terrible sufferings of England's impoverished people in the 18th century. To be poor, this speaker says, is not just to experience all kinds of pains and indignities, but to be rejected and mistreated by the rest of the world. In this excerpt from the poem, the speaker describes impoverished people's grueling day-to-day lives and their painful deaths—and observes, as well, that the wealthier people who *should* be helping them are seriously neglecting their duties. This polemical poem is a call for the wealthy to open their eyes to the poor's suffering and extend compassion (and material help!) to their fellow human beings.

The poor, the speaker observes, live in the most desperate and



SUMMARY

When the raging winter storms hit poor people's cottages and the icy wind blows straight through the cracks in the walls;

depressing conditions one can imagine. In winter, for instance, icy winds whistle straight through their cracked and inadequate walls. Their children, who are "with hunger pinched," cry for food their parents can't give them. There's no escape in sleep: with only a "tattered blanket" for warmth (and a whole lot of fleas for company), the poor can't even get a good night's rest. And heaven forbid that anyone in the family get sick. With only the "well-meaning ignorance" of untrained friends for help, the poor die in needless agony.

That's all bad enough, the speaker suggests. But the way that wealthier people respond to poverty makes the poor's situation even more desperate and humiliating. Doctors, for instance, won't come near the sickbeds of the poor without a "golden fee." The "parish" (that is, the local church authorities) seem *pleased* when the poor die, since it spares them doling out even the "reluctant pay" (or grudging charity) they offer. Most well-to-do people, for that matter, seem to lack "the will to give" to their impoverished neighbors—and even treat them as out-and-out criminals, threatening them with "the dungeon and the whipping-post."

Even in this brief excerpt, the speaker doesn't need to spell out what feels so wrong with this picture: it speaks for itself. The poor suffer terribly—and though their suffering is no fault of their own, their richer neighbors treat them with condescension, suspicion, and even outright cruelty. This, the appalled speaker implies, is no way to run a society.

Where this theme appears in the poem:

- Lines 1-36



LINE-BY-LINE ANALYSIS

LINES 1-6

*When winter's rage upon the cottage falls,
And the wind rushes through the gaping walls,
When ninepence must their daily wants supply,
With hunger pinched and cold, the children cry;
The gathered sticks but little warmth afford,
And half-supplied the platter meets the board.*

"The Complaints of Poverty" is Nicholas James's long tirade against the sufferings of the poor and the selfish cruelty of the upper classes in 18th-century Britain. Supposedly spoken by a chorus of the poor themselves, the poem ends up sounding a lot more like an outside observer's outraged remarks on what poverty does to people.

The poem's form—elegant heroic [couplets](#)—suggests that this is a poem meant to make a political point. Heroic couplets are paired rhyming lines of [iambic pentameter](#)—that is, lines of five iambs, metrical feet with a da-DUM rhythm. Here's how that sounds in the first two lines of this excerpt:

When win- | ter's rage | upon | the cot- | tage falls,
And the | wind rush- | es through | the gap- | ing walls,

Notice that the second line here plays with its rhythms, pushing two stresses together into a [spondee](#) (a foot with a strong DUM-DUM rhythm) to capture the force of that awful wind against those inadequate walls.

Heroic couplets were a popular form among 18th-century poets, admired both for their elegance and their flexibility. In choosing this form, James seems to be directing this poem to an educated audience that knows something about stylish poetry—an audience, the poem will suggest, that could also probably be doing a little more to help out its less fortunate neighbors.

The first lines of this excerpt describe day-to-day life for a poor family in 18th-century Britain. When "winter's rage" comes along, the speaker says (in a moment of [personification](#) that suggests the very *seasons* are cruel to the poor), an already difficult situation gets even worse. Besides cold winds that rush through the "gaping," cracked-open walls of the poor's cottages, both food and fuel become scarce. Living on a paltry "ninepence," families can't afford to feed their children.

The speaker evokes this predicament through spare, straightforward, indignant [imagery](#):

With hunger pinched and cold, the children cry;
The gathered sticks but little warmth afford,
And half-supplied the platter meets the board.

The image of children "pinched" by hunger and cold suggests both that the children *look* pinched (in the sense of "scrawny and starved") and that they *feel* as if they're being pinched by their hunger pangs and the cruel, nippy winds. The "half-supplied," scanty plate their parents can provide them isn't nearly enough to fill their bellies or keep the cold from their little bones.

Powerful [anaphora](#) frames these lines as well:

When winter's rage upon the cottage falls,
And the wind rushes through the gaping walls,
When ninepence must their daily wants supply,
With hunger pinched and cold, the children cry;

The repeated "when" here feels grim, suggesting that these sufferings come around every winter, horribly predictable.

Already, readers get a flavor of Nicholas James's argumentative style. In spite of its fluent and orderly form, this poem won't sound elevated or intricate. Rather, it will paint a straightforward picture of how the 18th-century poor lived and died—and dare its better-off readers to look away.

LINES 7-14

*Returned at night, if wholesome viands fail,
He from the pipe extracts a smoky meal:
And when, to gather strength and still his woes,
He seeks his last redress in soft repose,
The tattered blanket, erst the fleas' retreat,
Denies his shiv'ring limbs sufficient heat;
Teased with the squalling babes' nocturnal cries,
He restless on the dusty pillow lies.*

Now, the speaker goes on, the father of the family comes home. His children, remember, were already eating from a "half-supplied" plate; now, there are no "wholesome viands" (nourishing foods) whatsoever left over for him. Instead, he has to make do with the "smoky meal" of a pipe's worth of tobacco—a [metaphor](#) that stresses just how insubstantial and unsatisfying such an airy dinner would be.

Hungry and troubled by "woes"—it's not easy to watch your children cry from cold and hunger, after all—this man tries to find a "last redress in soft repose." In other words, he tries to escape from his sufferings into a peaceful sleep. *Surely*, the speaker invites readers to think, *sleep is one pleasure you don't need money to enjoy?*

Not so. With insufficient and filthy bedding, a whole fiesta of fleas for company, and the sound of the kids crying in his ears, there's no hope for this man: he'll lie awake all night.

There's something particularly painful and insulting about being so impoverished you can't sleep. The [imagery](#) of the "tattered blanket" and "dusty pillow" makes it clear that the simplest comforts are denied this unhappy man, and that the insults of poverty extend even to the most private corners of his life.

The speaker describes an everyman here, a generic representative for a whole community rather than a specific character. This dreadful predicament, that choice suggests, is the same for all kinds of struggling people.

LINES 15-20

*But when pale sickness wounds with direful blow,
Words but imperfectly his mis'ry show;
Unskilful how to treat the fierce disease,
Well-meaning ignorance curtails our days.
In a dark room and miserable bed
Together lie the living and the dead.*

Ordinary daily life is hard enough for that poor everyman, the speaker goes on. But when he gets ill, "words but imperfectly his mis'ry show": the speaker can't even *describe* how bad the man's life gets.

Here, illness is [personified](#) as a cruel figure, a "pale" being that "wounds with direful," or dreadful, "blow," violently striking the unfortunate man. Like the earlier personification of winter, this

[metaphor](#) suggests that the world is actively *cruel* to the poor. The indifferent turn of the seasons and the random bad luck of illness, in other words, feel like conscious enemies when one is also dealing with desperate poverty.

Facing illness without any money, the speaker suggests, means having to rely on "well-meaning ignorance"—the kindly intended but untrained assistance of friends or neighbors, rather than professional help from a doctor. Because these folks are "unskilful how to treat the fierce disease" (or lacking the skills/knowledge to tend to the sick), their attempts to help can only "curtail our days," shorten sufferers' lives.

Worse still:

*In a dark room and miserable bed
Together lie the living and the dead.*

These lines present an appalling situation in the plainest language possible. As the speaker said above, it's hard to put into words just how it would feel for a sick person to helplessly share a bed with a dead family member—so the poem doesn't try. It just starkly lays out what happens and leaves readers to absorb the shock of the image on their own.

LINES 21-26

*Oh shocking scene! Fate sweeps whole tribes away,
And frees the parish of th' reluctant pay!
Where's the physician now, whom heav'n ordains
Fate to arrest, and check corroding pains?
Or he's detained by those of high degree,
Or won't prescribe without a golden fee.*

"Oh shocking scene!" the speaker cries, expressing what may well be the reader's own feelings after encountering that image of the sick forced to lie in the same narrow bed as the dead bodies of their families. The poem swiftly channels that shock into outrage:

*[...] Fate sweeps whole tribes away,
And frees the parish of th' reluctant pay!*

The harsh /p/ [alliteration](#) there makes it sound as if the speaker is practically spitting as he denounces the parish, the local church office. The officials there might not be so shocked by grim and untimely deaths as the reader and the speaker, these lines suggest. They might, rather, be *relieved* not to have to dole out the measly and grudging financial help they offered to those now-dead families. These supposedly charitable institutions, the speaker implies, are emphatically not doing their jobs, either in spirit or in practice.

Nor are the doctors:

*Where's the physician now, whom heav'n ordains
Fate to arrest, and check corroding pains?*

Or he's detained by those of high degree,
Or won't prescribe without a golden fee.

Like the clergy, the speaker feels, doctors are "ordain[ed]" to their task: that is, they have a God-given responsibility to ease suffering wherever they find it, to stand up to the cruel "Fate" that wipes out whole families. But these doctors, like the churches, seem more interested in their own wealth than the good of the people they should be serving. Rather than soothing the "corroding," devouring agonies of poor people's illnesses, they scamper off to tend to those of "high degree"—that is, people of higher social status. They're unwilling to treat anyone who can't offer them a "golden fee," a hefty payment.

All the people who should be helping the poor, in other words, are instead looking out for number one: trying to keep their own pockets lined. The doctors, in particular, also seem driven to separate themselves from people they see as lower-class and less important than those of "high degree." Not just indifferent "Fate," but a greedy and snobbish *society* condemn the poor to their hard lives and miserable deaths.

LINES 27-32

*But should old age bring on its rev'rend hoar,
When strength decayed admits his toil no more,
He begs itinerant, with halting pace,
And, mournful, tells his melancholy case,
With meagre cheek and formidable beard,
A tattered dress of various rags prepared.*

If the poor everyman whose life the poem has been tracing makes it through years of hunger, cold, and sickness to old age, the speaker continues, his troubles still won't be over. In fact, his problems will get worse, since his "decayed" strength will no longer allow him to work.

Describing the old man's "hoar[y]," white-haired head, the speaker reminds readers that the white hair of old age should be treated as "rev'rend": as venerable, honorable. The elderly *should* be respected and cared for.

Instead, too weak for labor, this poor man has no choice but to become a wandering beggar, limping sadly from place to place and telling his tale of woe. He's in bad shape:

With meagre cheek and formidable beard,
A tattered dress of various rags prepared.

The [imagery](#) in this passage paints a poignant picture of intense neglect. Besides his sad, ragged clothing, this poor man doesn't even have the resources for a shave: his "formidable beard" is unkempt and overgrown as a bramble patch. That beard is the only formidable thing left about him, too. His "meagre," thin cheek reveals that he's as hungry now as he's ever been. (Notice the [alliteration](#) the speaker uses in this passage, too: all

the drawn-out /m/ sounds in "mournful," "melancholy," and "meagre" make the lines hum with sad music.)

LINES 33-36

*Base covetise, who wants the soul to give,
Directs the road where richer neighbours live;
And pride, unmindful of its parent dust,
Scares with the dungeon and the whipping-post.*

All through this excerpt, the speaker has traced the life of a poor everyman and his family. Now, he turns to these unfortunate people's neighbors—the people whom one might hope would want to help them out in their sufferings. But no such luck:

Base covetise, who wants the soul to give,
Directs the road where richer neighbours live;

Confronted with a sad, starving, elderly beggar, "base covetise"—that is, lowly greed, here serving as a [metonym](#) for lowly, greedy *people*—just points the way to its wealthier neighbors' houses down the street. Those who are relatively well off, in other words, don't see it as *their* responsibility to look out for their suffering fellow human beings. Perhaps the sight of this poor old man even makes them feel *greedier*, more determined to cling to their money and avoid his fate if they can.

If the old man follows these selfish neighbors' directions and goes down the road to the homes of the wealthy, he won't find what he's looking for:

And pride, unmindful of its parent dust,
Scares with the dungeon and the whipping-post.

"Pride"—another metonym, this time for arrogant and proud people—is even crueler to the old man than the merely selfish neighbors were. Rather than just turning him away, they threaten to treat him like an outright criminal—to imprison him or whip him for begging.

They react this way, the speaker says, because they're "unmindful of their parent dust." This line [alludes](#) to language from the Bible and from the Book of Common Prayer (the official prayerbook of the Church of England, Britain's state church during the 18th century):

- In the biblical creation story (or [one](#) of the [two](#) versions the Book of Genesis tells, anyway), God is said to make Adam from the dust of the earth.
- And the burial service in the Book of Common Prayer reminds mourners that everyone comes from the earth and returns to the earth: "ashes to ashes, dust to dust."

In other words, the haughty people who treat the poor like dirt have forgotten that the poor are people just like them. All people, this moment suggests, share an important, essential equality. To be human is to have needs, to suffer, and to die someday. In pushing the poor away and treating them like criminals, this poem's outraged speaker suggests, the prideful and greedy are forgetting (or just fearfully rejecting) their shared humanity.



POETIC DEVICES

IMAGERY

The poem's grim [imagery](#) depicts the exhausting day-to-day sufferings the poor have to navigate. Many of these have to do with simple, constant discomfort.

In the winter, for instance, "the wind rushes through the gaping walls" of the poor's cottages—an image that suggests just how little protection those cracked walls offer, and also subtly suggests that the cottages themselves might seem to gape in helpless horror at what's happening within them. Inside, the speaker observes children "with hunger pinched and cold." Here, the children might be "pinched" in the sense of "gaunt and skinny"—but they also might feel as if hunger and cold are actually *pinching* them, like mean little elves.

Their parents don't have it much easier. Trying to escape their sufferings in sleep, they find that a "tattered blanket" crawling with fleas doesn't provide much in the way of warmth, and end up lying awake all night on a "dusty pillow." These images conjure up a bed that offers no rest: here, even the place that should provide "soft repose" is only another small daily torture chamber.

Things get even worse if someone in the family gets sick, the speaker continues—[personifying](#) sickness itself as "pale sickness," like a thin-cheeked horseman of the apocalypse. Without the help of a doctor, the poor are helplessly condemned to lie "in a dark room," the living and the dying cooped up in the same "miserable bed." This shadowy moment suggests that the poor die in the dark in more ways than one: their "dark room" also gestures to the way the rest of society shuts these suffering people out of their minds.

Should a poor person survive all these miseries, the speaker observes, they can't exactly look forward to a cheerful, thriving old age. As soon as they can't work anymore, old men whose "rev'rend hoar" (that is, respectable grey heads) should be settled in an armchair somewhere instead find themselves begging on the road, limping along with "halting pace," wearing a "tattered dress of various rags," their "meagre," scrawny cheeks hidden beneath an unkempt and "formidable beard."

The speaker's vision of this frail old beggar—particularly that "formidable beard," a vivid image of involuntary self-neglect—is

designed to evoke pity. But pity, the speaker says again and again, is precisely what better-off people can't seem to find it in their hearts to offer their suffering neighbors.

Where Imagery appears in the poem:

- **Lines 1-2:** "When winter's rage upon the cottage falls, / And the wind rushes through the gaping walls,"
- **Line 4:** "With hunger pinched and cold, the children cry;"
- **Lines 11-14:** "The tattered blanket, erst the fleas' retreat, / Denies his shiv'ring limbs sufficient heat; / Teased with the squalling babes' nocturnal cries, / He restless on the dusty pillow lies."
- **Line 15:** "But when pale sickness wounds with direful blow,"
- **Lines 19-20:** "In a dark room and miserable bed / Together lie the living and the dead."
- **Line 27:** "rev'rend hoar,"
- **Lines 29-32:** "He begs itinerant, with halting pace, / And, mournful, tells his melancholy case, / With meagre cheek and formidable beard, / A tattered dress of various rags prepared."

METAPHOR

The speaker uses [metaphor](#) to make the sufferings of the poor feel tangible—and terribly unfair.

When cold weather comes, the speaker observes, the poor have a particularly hard time: it's as if "winter's rage" has fallen on them. This [personification](#) suggests that the season is so difficult for the poor that it's as if it has it in for them—but also subtly invites readers to ask whose misplaced "rage" *really* makes these people's lives hard. Winter, after all, didn't lodge these people in houses with "gaping walls" and no fuel for the fire.

Nor did winter deprive the poor of food to the extent that they can only turn to their pipes for an inadequate "smoky meal." Smoking to try to settle your hunger pangs, this metaphor suggests, doesn't do any good: a smoky meal is an awfully insubstantial and unsatisfying one.

Another dangerous personification comes along when the speaker imagines personified "pale sickness" dealing a "direful blow"—a dreadful punch—to already weak, starving, and miserable people. Here, again, the world itself seems cruelly to have turned against the poor. Sickness can slap anyone around, but it's that much harder to face when you don't have money for a doctor.

To round it all off, other people are just as cruel as the winter and illness. The better-off, the speaker declares in a [metonym](#), become embodiments of "pride" itself—and pride doesn't like to remember its "parent dust." In other words, wealthy people prefer not to recall either that they're made of mortal clay (just like the poor people they neglect and ignore) or that they and

the poor share common ancestors: Adam, the first parent, whom (according to the book of Genesis) God made from the dust.

Where Metaphor appears in the poem:

- **Line 1:** "winter's rage"
- **Line 8:** "He from the pipe extracts a smoky meal"
- **Line 15:** "pale sickness wounds with direful blow"
- **Line 33:** "Base covetise"
- **Line 35:** "pride, unmindful of its parent dust,"

ANAPHORA

In this excerpt, [anaphora](#) helps to evoke the dreadful inescapability of the poor's sufferings: wherever an impoverished man turns, the speaker suggests, he runs into another difficulty.

Listen to the way the speaker frames these lines describing the life and death of an impoverished everyman:

When winter's rage upon the cottage falls,
And the wind rushes through the gaping walls,
When ninepence must their daily wants supply,
With hunger pinched and cold, the children cry;
[...]

And **when**, to gather strength and still his woes,
He seeks his last redress in soft repose,
[...]

But **when** pale sickness wounds with direful blow,
Words but imperfectly his mis'ry show;

That repeated "when" stresses the idea that, as the poor turn from one basic daily activity to the next, they find a new trouble every time. It's as if the poem's vision tracks a whole unpleasant day—and then, eventually, a whole unpleasant *life*, leaping from the grind of the everyday to the sad, painful end in a crowded bed.

There's a pointed bit of anaphora in the speaker's description of the doctor who fails to appear at that crowded bed's side, too:

Or he's detained by those of high degree,
Or won't prescribe without a golden fee.

This double "or" (which in the 18th century meant the same as our "either [...] or") underscores the point that, whatever reason the doctor has for not turning up, it's sure to involve greed: there's not all that much difference between these two explanations for his absence at the deathbeds of the poor.

Where Anaphora appears in the poem:

- **Line 1:** "When"

- **Line 3:** "When"
- **Line 9:** "when"
- **Line 15:** "when"
- **Line 25:** "Or"
- **Line 26:** "Or"

ALLITERATION

Forceful [alliteration](#) emphasizes the speaker's images of dire poverty and their outrage against those who let it go on happening.

Listen, for instance, to these evocative lines:

When winter's rage upon the cottage falls,
And the wind rushes through the gaping walls,

That /w/ sound captures the howl of the wind as it rushes through those cracked and "gaping walls."

When the speaker describes a poor man just trying to get some rest, meanwhile, intense alliteration focuses readers' attention on the day's last insult:

And when, to gather strength and still his woes,
He seeks his last redress in soft repose,
The tattered blanket, erst the fleas' retreat,
Denies his shiv'ring limbs sufficient heat;

The repeated /r/ and /s/ sounds focus and heighten these lines, inviting readers to pay special attention here—to really imagine what it's like when you can't even escape from your troubles in sleep.

Similar heightened alliterative language appears in these chilling lines:

In a dark room and miserable bed
Together lie the living and the dead.

The language here is horrifically matter-of-fact: *That's just what happens*, the grim speaker seems to suggest. But the alliteration frames and emphasizes these plain words, lifting them confrontationally off the page.

Where Alliteration appears in the poem:

- **Line 1:** "When winter's"
- **Line 2:** "wind," "walls"
- **Line 4:** "cold," "cry"
- **Line 9:** "strength," "still"
- **Line 10:** "redress," "repose"
- **Line 11:** "retreat"
- **Line 15:** "when," "wounds with"
- **Line 16:** "Words"

- **Line 18:** "days"
- **Line 19:** "dark"
- **Line 20:** "lie," "living," "dead"
- **Line 21:** "scene," "sweeps"
- **Line 22:** "parish," "pay"
- **Line 25:** "detained," "degree"
- **Line 30:** "mournful," "melancholy"
- **Line 31:** "meagre"
- **Line 34:** "road," "richer"
- **Line 35:** "pride," "parent," "dust"
- **Line 36:** "dungeon"

"his failing strength will no longer allow him to work."

Itinerant (Line 29) - Wandering.

Halting pace (Line 29) - Stumbling, limping footsteps.

Meagre (Line 31) - Thin and scrawny.

Formidable (Line 31) - Impressive, huge.

Base (Line 33) - Lowly, unworthy.

Covetise (Line 33) - Greed, covetousness. The speaker is using the word here as a [metonym](#) for greedy *people*.

Wants (Line 33) - Lacks.

Unmindful (Line 35) - Not thinking of, not heeding.



VOCABULARY

Gaping (Line 2) - Cracked, wide-open.

Afford (Line 5) - Offer, give.

Half-supplied the platter meets the board (Line 6) - That is, "the plate comes to the table only half-full."

Wholesome viands (Line 7) - Nourishing foods.

Still (Line 9) - To quiet or calm.

Redress (Line 10) - Solution, remedy, assistance.

Erst the fleas' retreat (Line 11) - That is, "until recently the place where fleas hung out."

Teased (Line 13) - Troubled, bothered.

Squalling (Line 13) - Crying, fussing.

Direful (Line 15) - Dreadful, terrible.

Unskilful how to treat the fierce disease (Line 17) - That is, "not knowing how to treat the terrible illness."

Curtails (Line 18) - Cuts short.

Frees the parish of th' reluctant pay (Line 22) - That is, "Allows the local church to stop providing even the grudging charity they'd been offering."

Ordains (Line 23) - Gives a responsibility to, nominates, appoints.

Check (Line 24) - Stop, prevent, work against.

Corroding (Line 24) - Destructive. Particularly used to describe things that destroy by eating away, like acid.

Detained (Line 25) - Held back, engaged.

High degree (Line 25) - High social status.

Golden fee (Line 26) - That is, a steep payment.

Rev'rend (Line 27) - A contraction of "reverend," "worthy of respect."

Hoar (Line 27) - White hair (so called because hair growing white resembles hoarfrost).

Strength decayed admits his toil no more (Line 28) - That is,



FORM, METER, & RHYME

FORM

"The Complaints of Poetry" is a long polemical poem: an indignant examination of the terrible conditions in which the poor were living in James's own 18th-century England, as well as a call for wealthier people to *do* something about this awful situation. The excerpt covered in this guide is 36 lines long, but the complete poem goes on considerably longer. It describes not just the poor physical conditions in which the poor live and die (as this excerpt does), but also the psychological and emotional battering they take—for instance, the strain that poverty puts on marriages and moral compasses.

James writes his screed in elegant, formal heroic [couplets](#): that is, paired rhyming lines of [iambic](#) pentameter (lines of 10 syllables arranged in an unstressed-stressed, da-DUM, pattern). Popular since Chaucer, this form was especially prominent during the 17th and 18th centuries, when poets like [John Dryden](#) and [Alexander Pope](#) adopted it for their [satires](#) and classical translations. In choosing this form, James marks himself out as a skilled and educated man—someone whom the sort of people who *read* stylish, refined verse (and who could probably be digging a little deeper into their pockets) should listen to.

METER

"The Complaints of Poverty" is written in heroic [couplets](#): paired, rhyming lines of [iambic](#) pentameter. In iambic pentameter, lines are built from five iambs, metrical feet with a da-DUM rhythm. Here's how that sounds in line 1:

When win- | ter's rage | upon | the cot- | tage falls,

This is one of the most popular and familiar [meters](#) in English-language poetry—perhaps because a lot of spoken English falls naturally into an iambic rhythm.

It's also a flexible meter, and poets occasionally move stresses around for dramatic effect. Listen to what happens in line 2, for

example:

And the | wind rush- | es through | the gap- | ing walls

Here, the speaker pushes two of the line's stresses together to form a [spondee](#), a foot with a DUM-DUM rhythm. That powerful foot embodies the force of that terrible, wall-piercing wind in sound.

RHYME SCHEME

"The Complaints of Poverty" is written in [couplets](#), and its [rhyme scheme](#) thus runs AABBC... and so on. More precisely, these are *heroic couplets*: couplets written in [iambic pentameter](#). This was a popular form in the 18th century; Enlightenment-era writers often used heroic couplets for their sharp-tongued satires.

In this case, a tight, snappy, pattering [rhyme scheme](#) harmonizes with the speaker's urgency and outrage. Couplets often feel quick and orderly, and here they support the feeling that the speaker is making a thorough and well-considered argument against the appalling conditions the poor live in.



SPEAKER

The poem's speaker is—purportedly—a chorus of the poor, angrily addressing the rich. But the poem doesn't maintain this perspective very firmly. Its voice ends up feeling more like the voice of a social critic, and a *furios* one at that. A person with a compassionate heart and a sharp eye for detail, this speaker sees the sufferings of the poor clearly and feels them acutely. They see, as well, that people who *aren't* poor tend to turn their backs on those who haven't been so lucky as they, treating them as criminals and grudging every penny of charity they offer them.

While they're intensely sympathetic to the poor (and seem to have some direct observations of their sufferings), this speaker also seems to look at them from a slight distance. In both style and tone, this is a poem for the wealthy people who should be doing more to help—a category it seems fairly likely the speaker, writing formally in elegant heroic [couplets](#), belongs to.

It would be reasonable to interpret this poem's speaker as Nicholas James himself. This is the kind of polemical poem born of a writer's strong moral and political feeling.



SETTING

This poem is set in poet Nicholas James's own time and place: England in the mid-18th century. This, as James observes, was a time when to be poor often meant to suffer horribly: to live in cold, cramped, and unsanitary lodgings, to go without sufficient food, and to die uncared for. Adding insult to injury, the speaker

observes, the people who *should* have been helping often did just the opposite, offering the poor scanty, grudging charity at best and whippings or imprisonment at worst. To be poor in this era, James suggests, was to be treated like a criminal for no fault of your own—besides suffering daily pains, deprivations, and indignities. This, "The Complaints of Poverty" cries, is no way for a civilized society to treat its citizens.



CONTEXT

LITERARY CONTEXT

Scholars know very little about Nicholas James, the author of this poem—not even his dates of birth and death. His name and his work survive in a single published volume, *Poems on Several Occasions* (1742).

What we *can* say about James is that he lived in (and clearly responded strongly to) the Enlightenment era, a post-Renaissance period of revolutionary social and philosophical change. Enlightenment thinkers, motivated by a deep belief in the power of reason, began to question ancient certainties, from the rightful order of society to the existence of God.

James was a man of his era, a person not afraid to question and satirize the culture in which he lived. But where his contemporaries (like [Alexander Pope](#)) styled their social critiques with lofty, elegant wit, "The Complaints of Poverty" takes a more direct and polemical approach, railing against the sufferings of the poor and the indifference of the rich.

In this, he might be seen as a precursor of later Romantic figures like [Blake](#) and [Wordsworth](#), whose poetry [prophetically raged](#) against society's cruelty or [sympathized intimately](#) with impoverished people.

HISTORICAL CONTEXT

As James observes, 18th-century Britain was a rough time and place in which to be poor—and a *lot* of people were poor. A population explosion across the 18th century meant that British cities were severely overcrowded, filthy, and strapped for resources; a severe grain shortage didn't help matters. Poverty was rife, and there was little support for poor people beyond the kind of sparse and grudging charity the poem describes.

The best one might hope for after falling on hard times was to end up in a [workhouse](#), a charity home that in reality was often more like a prison. In these institutions, impoverished people were made to live in sex-segregated barracks, follow a strict code of behavior, and work at dull and grueling menial jobs—besides being exposed to all kinds of ignominy and abuse. Some desperate people were known to have starved to death rather than enter a workhouse.

These stressful and depressing conditions brewed discontent

and rebellion. Sometimes, word of a new workhouse being built [led to out-and-out rioting](#). The struggles of the poor across Europe during this era would eventually contribute to massive political change, even revolution: the [French Revolution](#) itself ran on the fuel of working people's fury against a tiny and lavishly wealthy upper class.

- [More of the Poem](#) — Read a longer excerpt from "The Complaints of Poverty" (including James's remarks on what a life of poverty does to people's relationships and morality). (<https://books.google.com/books?id=gyDICGZavfkC&lpg=PA342&dq=the%20complaints>)



MORE RESOURCES

EXTERNAL RESOURCES

- [Poems on Several Occasions](#) — Take a look at a few pages from Poems on Several Occasions, the collection in which this poem appeared. (<https://www.abebooks.com/first-edition/POEMS-OCCASIONS-JAMES-Nicholas-Truro-printed/30656997324/bd>)
- [Poverty in James's Britain](#) — Learn more about the very real problem of poverty in James's 18th-century world. (<https://www.bl.uk/georgian-britain/articles/poverty-in-georgian-britain>)



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